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English Composition II

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Annotated Bibliography

Vallet, Guillaume. “Rebuilding the Economy of the Home – for the Emergence of the ‘New Woman’: Charlotte Perkins Gilman’s Pioneering Thoughts.” European Journal of the History of Economic Thought, vol. 30, no. 1, Feb. 2023, pp. 62–85. EBSCOhost, https://doi.org/10.1080/09672567.2022.2108870.

Vallet dives into Charlotte Perkins Gilman’s radical take on what the home should look like. Gilman wasn’t just pushing for women’s rights, but she wanted to completely revolutionize how the household operated. She believed that the traditional home setup was outdated and that it held women back by forcing them into unpaid and undervalued work. Vallet shows how Gilman pushed for women to gain economic freedom by restructuring home life. It was as if Gilman was turning it into a professional system. This would allow women to pursue meaningful work outside the home and finally be treated as equals in society. Gilman’s vision of the “New Woman” was bold. Her vision was someone educated, financially free, and no longer trapped in the shadows of men. This article helps paint a clearer picture of Gilman not just as a writer, but as someone who was seriously trying to reshape society at its core.

Annotated Bibliography

O'Donnell, Margaret G. "Charlotte Perkins Gilman's Economic Interpretation of the Role of Women at the Turn of the Century." Social Science Quarterly (University of Texas Press), vol. 69, no. 1, Mar. 1988, pp. 177–92. EBSCOhost, research.ebsco.com/linkprocessor/plink?id=af51177a-5de2-36cc-8732-91c8c61a17ec.

In this article, Nancy O'Donnell breaks down how Charlotte Perkins Gilman used economic theory to expose the invisible labor of women. O'Donnell argues that Gilman saw marriage and family life as an outdated transactional exchange where women's work like raising children and managing the home was both expected and undervalued. What stands out in O'Donnell's analysis is how Gilman flipped the script by using economic logic to challenge gender roles. O'Donnell shows how Gilman viewed female economic dependence as a key reason women were stuck in inequality. The article helps readers understand that Gilman wasn't just a strong voice for feminism, but she was also a social economist with ideas for how to redesign society. O'Donnell does a great job highlighting Gilman's vision of progress, and this source gives strong support when talking about how Gilman's work tied gender equality to economic change.

Annotated Bibliography

Davis, Cynthia J. “Love and Economics: Charlotte Perkins Gilman on ‘The Woman Question.’” ATQ, vol. 19, no. 4, Dec. 2005, pp. 243–58. EBSCOhost, research.ebsco.com/linkprocessor/plink?id=ee18d177-0fed-3f9b-8d4e-47188c934e19.

In this article, Davis explores how Gilman’s ideas in Women and Economics were not just political or theoretical, but that they were deeply personal as well. Gilman called for women’s economic independence and criticized the way traditional marriage kept women financially and emotionally dependent. Davis saw this and dug deeper into the contradictions between what Gilman preached and how she lived. Behind her bold claims was a woman fighting with her own desire for love, especially during her marriages and complicated relationships. Davis argues that Women and Economics was partly Gilman’s way of trying to convince herself that she didn’t have to choose between love and purpose, and that a woman could have both. This analysis doesn’t tear Gilman down, but actually makes her message more real and relatable. Davis shows how Gilman’s public writing was often a reflection of her private battles. This insight gives her arguments a more human and relatable punch.

Annotated Bibliography

Johnson, Greg. “Gilman’s Gothic Allegory: Rage and Redemption in ‘The Yellow Wallpaper.’” Studies in Short Fiction, vol. 26, no. 4, Sept. 1989, pp. 521–30. EBSCOhost, research.ebsco.com/linkprocessor/plink?id=76a4271a-911d-3fcb-987b-db4ce77b1772.

In this article, Greg Johnson flips the script on The Yellow Wallpaper, arguing that the narrator’s plunge into madness is actually a form of rebellion and artistic breakthrough. Instead of painting her as a victim who crumbles under pressure, Johnson shows how Gilman uses classic Gothic elements like the haunted house, isolation, and eerie imagery as a way to reveal the psychological torture women had to endure in the name of “treatment.” Johnson even compares the narrator to Emily Dickinson, highlighting how women writers used creativity to push back when their voices were ignored. The wallpaper itself becomes a symbol of societal control, and tearing it down is the narrator’s way of reclaiming her power. Johnson also points out how this story is Gilman’s literary revenge on the infamous “rest cure” prescribed to her. This article is powerful because it doesn’t just focus on the horror of the story. It dives into the deeper meaning, showing how the narrator’s madness is really about rage and redemption.

Annotated Bibliography

Weinbaum, Alys Eve. “Writing Feminist Genealogy: Charlotte Perkins Gilman, Racial Nationalism, and the Reproduction of Maternalist Feminism.” Feminist Studies, vol. 27, no. 2, June 2001, p. 271. EBSCOhost, https://doi.org/10.2307/3178758.

In this article, Weinbaum dives deep into the contradictions in Gilman’s legacy. Weinbaum argues that while Gilman was a pioneer for feminism, her ideas were heavily shaped by racial nationalism and a specific vision of white womanhood. Weinbaum unpacks how Gilman’s push for a maternalist society where mothers hold moral and social power was built around a racialized view of who deserved that power. Weinbaum doesn’t just call Gilman out, but she thoughtfully traces how Gilman’s writings helped define American feminism, but where they fell short as well. Her research shows that Gilman’s vision excluded marginalized women, which reinforced social hierarchies even when she claimed to abolish them. Weinbaum’s argument helps readers to see the full picture. Both the progress and the problems, which is key when studying influential figures like Gilman. It challenges readers not to overlook the flaws in historical feminist movements, especially when they still linger today.